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Beyond the Image: How Capturing Systems of Dehumanization as Art Encourages Reflection on the Dehumanized





The Union of Concerned Scientists' satellite database estimates that 500 to 600 satellites orbit Earth exclusively to capture data-rich images. This is part of a larger trend toward data collection and efficiency that has swept over contemporary life, governmental systems, and businesses. While these satellites provide important insights into geography and weather, their relentless pursuit of objectivity abstracts complex human experiences into cold statistics, exemplifying a broader surveillance paradigm that values numbers over nuanced individual lives. This abstraction is particularly evident in migration systems, where bureaucratic tools and surveillance technologies convert human lives into components of logistical processes framed in terms of borders, quotas, infractions, and trends. Artists Michael Danner and Noelle Mason engage with this phenomenon by critically examining the systems that perpetuate such abstraction in immigration. Danner's *Migration as Avant-Garde* is a collection of photographs that depicts the new ways migrants are pursuing their hopes for a better life alongside the challenges and structures they encounter. In contrast, Mason's "Ground Control" features a series of woven textiles that interpret the ASTER imagery photographs of the US-Mexico border regions captured by NASA's Terra satellite, transforming technological visuals into handcrafted, tactile art. Although the two works differ in presentation, both Danner's photograph from *Migration as Avant-Garde* and Mason's tapestry "Ground Control (Colorado River Delta)" create art that illustrates the dehumanization ingrained in border control while showcasing the bureaucratic and surveillance tools that reduce individuals to mere data. This forces the audience to reflect on the lives of the dehumanized, emphasizing the absence of human presence within the photographs. By directing the audience's focus toward the systems themselves rather than the individuals affected by them, these works expose the mechanisms of control that dictate what is seen and who remains invisible.

The bureaucratic and surveillance mechanisms central to immigration processes find their visual counterpart in Danner's and Mason's complete works, where human presence is systematically erased or obscured. While Danner's book *Migration as Avant-Garde* focuses more on human presence, his museum exhibit opts for the opposite approach. Instead of directly presenting migrants, both artists emphasize the structures that govern their movement and visibility. This strategic omission of human presence in the artworks forces the viewer to consider how migrants exist within these systems — as subjects of control rather than as autonomous individuals. When we consider both works as a whole, Danner's *Migration as Avant-Garde* showcases sterile, depopulated spaces — banks of surveillance monitors displaying real-time tracking data, immigration processing centers devoid of personal details, juxtaposed with stark, featureless landscapes where borders are marked not by people, but by fences, gates, and watchtowers — existing solely to track, process, and regulate migrants. The absence of personal immigrant presence in most of the photographs and the art exhibit presented by Danner draws attention to their subjugation within these systems, inviting viewers to reflect on the unseen individuals these mechanisms are designed to monitor. Mason's Ground Control, on the other hand, uses surveillance imagery as its medium, translating satellite photographs into woven textiles that further abstract and distort their subjects. By rendering technological representations of migration into a handcrafted, material form, Mason highlights how distant, impersonal observation transforms human movement into patterns, stripping migrants of identity and agency.

Danner's photograph above captures the environments in which migration becomes institutionalized, abstracting immigrants from their traditional human forms. The image displays technological tools for border enforcement, including weather and elevation maps, computers,

and cell phones. The central monitor prominently displays an infrared surveillance image of individuals, likely migrants, drifting in the water as they seek a better future. These individuals appear physically small compared to their surroundings, reflecting the metaphysical insignificance that Danner aims to convey regarding how immigrants are diminished within the migration system. Moreover, their physical forms lack any defining detail; it is impossible to discern their sex, age, gender, or personality. In fact, their bodies blend indistinguishably with the boat itself, discernible only by the viewer's perception of their silhouettes. Elements such as the engine positioned at the back of the boat might easily be mistaken for individuals at first glance. The people become physically and metaphorically indistinguishable from one another and from objects, mirroring the dehumanization inherent in the surveillance systems that facilitate large-scale migration, which view people as objects to be handled. Unlike other portrait photographs, which aim to convey their subject's individuality, the people in this photo are objectified in every sense of the word. The lack of defining features transforms these individuals into mere entities within a bureaucratic framework, reinforcing the idea that identity is secondary to categorization in the immigration process. In the name of efficiency, objectivity, and the "management" of the border, these individuals are reduced to data on a screen — identical to the next boat and the one before. Danner's photo intentionally erases the identities and personal existence of its subjects to illustrate the pervasive dehumanization evident in the "border crisis." Both presence and absence shape the perception of and reflection on this photo, as the photograph encourages viewers to recognize the human impact of these spaces precisely by omitting direct human representation. The tension between the highly detailed documentary style of Danner's work and the emotional void created by the absence of real people compels the viewer to reconstruct the emotional presence of migrants within these dehumanizing settings.

The sterile composition, filled with surveillance screens and control centers, suggests that the movement of people across borders is processed at a level of abstraction where they are no longer individuals but data points to be categorized, assessed, and managed.

Mason's work, *Ground Control (Colorado River Delta)*, similarly engages with themes of surveillance and distance but takes a different visual approach. Instead of showcasing physical border infrastructure, Mason employs a woven textile to reinterpret Colorado River Delta satellite images. Her choice of location reflects the delta's historical significance regarding immigration. Situated on the US-Mexico border, the delta is where the river historically flowed into the Gulf of California. While the river seldom flows to the sea now because of upstream water diversions, the delta area has historically acted as a migration pathway for individuals crossing from Mexico to the U.S. through the Sonoran Desert. This region is significant in immigration history, having become known as a dangerous passage for undocumented migrants trying to enter the U.S., with severe environmental conditions frequently leading to fatalities from dehydration and exposure. By selecting this storied landscape, Mason challenges the viewer to reconcile the region's turbulent past with surveillance technology's detached, modern gaze. However, this context is not immediately evident in the work itself. Instead, it might easily be mistaken for abstract art without the proper context, just as the land itself, when documented in a purely empirical form, can quickly lose sight of the human events and experiences that have occurred there. The deliberate absence of historical context within the textile prompts viewers to question how technological abstraction can erase the nuanced narratives of migration and survival. By stripping away context and personal identifiers, Mason's work highlights how surveillance technologies document movement without acknowledging the lived realities of those being tracked. In this manner, Mason's work similarly addresses dehumanization, as the

individuals she seeks to invoke through the work are absent from the piece itself. The original image, captured using the ASTER imaging system aboard NASA's Terra satellite, portrays the landscapes from a remote, detached perspective, reinforcing the impersonal nature of border surveillance. However, Mason's choice of medium – textiles – introduces a contradictory element. The fabrics were woven by hand in Mexico for the same cost it took to transport a family of four across the border into the United States. By weaving these images into the fabric, Mason reintroduces a sense of tactility and labor, contrasting the cold, mechanized gaze of satellite observation with the human act of creation. In doing so, she not only revives the physicality of a region once traversed by desperate migrants but also honors the artisanal labor rooted in local communities, reflecting the enduring human touch in a landscape marked by loss and survival. The woven distortions introduce visual noise, obscuring details and making it difficult to discern specific figures, reflecting how surveillance technologies fail to recognize migrants as individuals or the hardships they endure. This transformation of high-tech imagery into a handmade object challenges surveillance authority. It prompts the audience once again to consider the individuals who are starkly absent from the work by reintroducing the human element in its medium.

The interplay between the absence of human presence and the presence of dehumanizing systems in Michael Danner's *Migration as Avant-Garde* and Noelle Mason's *Ground Control* compels viewers to reflect on the individuals not actively present within the images — those subjected to these surveillance and bureaucratic structures. To grasp the relationship between presence and absence, we can refer to Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *phenomenology*, which offers a framework for understanding how this absence prompts reflection, as perception encompasses not only what is visibly represented but also the interaction between what is present and what is

hidden. In *Merleau-Ponty: A Phenomenological Philosophy of Mind and Body*, philosopher Sara Heinämaa elucidates that perception involves a "dynamic presence-absence structure" where elements not immediately visible influence how an image is interpreted. This implies that the absence of direct human presence in an image does not lessen its importance; rather, it enhances it, as the viewer is drawn to what is suggested rather than what is overtly shown. In this way, the absence of migrants in both works paradoxically intensifies their presence, as viewers are left to reconstruct the experiences of those whose lives are reduced to abstractions. Merleau-Ponty contends that "the perceived thing is present in perception in full flesh... It is not re-presented by any other entity" (Heinämaa 6), highlighting that absence is never simply a void; on the contrary, it fosters a heightened awareness of what is lacking. In the case of Danner and Mason's work, the absence of direct human representation does not erase the subject. Instead, it shifts the focus onto bureaucratic and surveillance mechanisms that reduce migrants to data, compelling the audience to consider how these systems mediate and distort human existence. Heinämaa further notes that perception is structured through the body's interaction with its environment, meaning that even in their absence, the migrant subjects remain central to the composition. Their presence is evoked through the structures intended to control them — tracking systems, border surveillance imagery, and administrative spaces — forcing the viewer to recognize their existence through the mechanisms designed to suppress their visibility. The absence of clear physical bodies, then, does not negate their presence but rather compels the audience to reconstruct their existence within the image, aligning with Merleau-Ponty's argument that what is not seen can be as perceptually significant as what is seen.

Both Danner and Mason challenge the audience to confront how dehumanization operates through abstraction. In *Migration as Avant-Garde*, migrants are absent because they

exist only as subjects of surveillance, seen but not recognized as individuals. In Ground Control, they are further abstracted into woven patterns, reduced to spectral traces within a system that governs their movement from afar. Through these visual strategies, the artists demonstrate how migration is mediated by technologies that prioritize control over humanity. By erasing human presence, they expose the machinery of dehumanization itself, urging viewers to critically engage with the systems that dictate who is visible, who is obscured, and ultimately who is rendered invisible — lost to a system that remains indifferent to their fate, as it perceives them as mere data, nothing more, nothing less.

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